Notice, Renewal, Redetermination, Change in Circumstances: The After-Approval Words and What to Write Down About Each

Seventeen terms in one plain line each, for a family that hasn't needed them yet.

Renewal. Redetermination. Change in circumstances. Dad isn't on Medicaid, and nobody is sending him letters with these words in them. If Medicaid ever comes up, it would be nice to have met them once already. Here they are, each in a plain line, with what a family planning ahead might write down.

Lines marked with a number come from a public source. The others say only what kind of thing the word names in the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, because what it would mean for Dad depends on his state and his situation. The definitions are for following a conversation. They aren't for working out where Dad would stand.

The program and who runs it

Medicaid

A joint federal and state program that helps cover medical costs for certain groups of people, among them older adults and people with disabilities. Each state decides how to run its own, and it may have another name in your state. [1] [2]

WRITE DOWN What the program is called in Dad's state, if you know. If you don't, that's a question for the list.

State Medicaid agency

The office that runs Medicaid in a state. Each state operates its own program, following federal rules, and Medicaid.gov keeps a directory of every state's agency. [3] [4]

WRITE DOWN The name of the agency in Dad's state. There's no need to call it.

Words from after an approval

Approval letter

The letter a state sends when it approves a person for Medicaid coverage. [1]

WRITE DOWN Nothing for now. If you've heard what comes after one, write down what you heard and who told you.

Ongoing eligibility

The roadmap's words for the idea that qualifying isn't settled once: a state reviews a person's information again to decide whether they still qualify. [5]

WRITE DOWN What your family has been told about this, and what you're assuming.

Notice

A letter from the state about a person's coverage. The federal renewal flyer says it tells a person whether a form has to be completed or other information sent. [5]

WRITE DOWN Where Dad's official mail goes now, and who he'd want opening it if he ever wanted a hand.

Renewal

The state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify. States are required to do this periodically. [5] [6]

WRITE DOWN A question: “How often would this happen in Dad's state, and what would it ask for?”

Redetermination

Used in the sources below for the same review as a renewal: the state determining again whether a person is eligible. [6]

WRITE DOWN That the two words go together, so neither is a surprise.

Renewal form or request for information

Something a state may send as part of a renewal. States are meant to use the data they already have first, and to send forms and requests for documents when that isn't enough. [5] [7]

WRITE DOWN Where Dad's statements and other records are kept, and who besides Dad can reach them.

Change in circumstances

A change in a person's life after enrollment, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income. States have procedures for people to report changes that may affect eligibility. Which changes a state wants reported is for its agency to say. [6]

WRITE DOWN The changes your family expects in the next few years, each with a rough date and a question mark.

Living arrangement and care setting

The roadmap's words for where a person lives and where they receive care. The federal guide to Medicaid notes that states have special rules for people who live in nursing homes. What those are is for a professional who knows the state. [1]

WRITE DOWN Where Dad lives now, who lives with him, and any move the family has talked about.

Appeal (fair hearing)

An administrative process that lets a person challenge certain Medicaid decisions made by their state. The state must tell people in writing how to ask for one. [3]

WRITE DOWN Nothing for now. It's enough to know the word, and that the instructions come in the state's own letter.

Money, records and the family's routine

Unexpected money

The roadmap's words for money nobody planned on: an inheritance, a gift received, insurance proceeds, the proceeds of a property sale, a refund. No rule for how it is treated is given here. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility. [2]

WRITE DOWN Anything the family expects, such as an inheritance, as a question to ask before anyone acts.

Recordkeeping and the document system

Keeping financial, legal and care records in one known place. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests a safe, easily accessible location, with trusted family told where to find things, and its guide for people managing a relative's money adds a list of what is received and spent, with dates and reasons. [8] [2]

WRITE DOWN Where each kind of record is kept, who can get to it, and when it was last updated. “Don't know” is a fair entry.

Family responsibilities

In this roadmap, who in the family would do what: open the mail, keep the folder, make the calls. Whether anyone has legal authority to act for Dad is a separate question, and it belongs to an elder law attorney.

WRITE DOWN The names Dad gives you, and a blank line wherever no one is named yet.

Review schedule

In this roadmap, a date the family picks to look at all of it again, and the kinds of events that would prompt an earlier look: a change in health, finances, family, legal papers or care.

WRITE DOWN The date, and who will be at the table.

Triggers

In this roadmap, the events that would move a family from planning ahead to active Medicaid management, when your Medicaid planner and the rest of the professional team are brought in. Which events those are for Dad is worked out with your Medicaid planner.

WRITE DOWN The events your family thinks would change things, written as guesses.

Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System

What this step produces in the roadmap: a review schedule, a document system, what to keep an eye on, family responsibilities and triggers. It is a way of staying organized. It isn't a decision about eligibility.

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet. Your notes on records, names and changes are what it starts from.

What this sheet doesn't do

It describes words. It doesn't say what any of them would require of your family, give a date or a limit, or tell you whether Dad would qualify for anything. Those answers come from the Medicaid agency in his state, your Medicaid planner and an elder law attorney. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've met the words once, and you know what you'd write down beside each. The planning interview uses the same plain language: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
3. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Understanding Medicaid Fair Hearings
4. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?
5. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
6. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
7. National Center on Law and Elder Rights (Administration for Community Living), Responding to Common Medicaid Unwinding Issues for Dual Eligibles
8. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness